the dust, the desert wind, the myriad of flies. The whole camp smelled like a charnel house. No person could take three steps in camp, anywhere, without seeing a dead or dying man or animal.'[35]

Lack of provisions meant that the soldiers' food had now to be cut from half- to quarter-rations. The camp followers were reduced to eating 'the fried skins of sheep, the congealed blood of animals, and such roots as they could pick up in the neighbourhood'.[36] Random incidents of savage violence continued to unnerve everyone. On 3 April William Hough recorded in his diary: 'Two Serjts. Of Arty. trepanned while out shooting, and mutilated while in the act of giving a pinch of snuff.'[37] Horses too weak to continue had to be shot in large numbers, while much baggage had to be abandoned and burned to prevent it falling into the hands of the Baluch.[38]

'It was the mouth of hell,' remembered the sepoy Sita Ram.

> The water in the few wells was bitter and everything, even the firewood, had to be transported by camels. The Baluchis now began to harass us by night attacks and drove off long strings of our camels. The heat was such that many died from the effects – one day thirty-five fell victim to it. At this stage the sepoys of the Company army had almost determined to return to India and there were signs of mutiny in several of the regiments. However, partly on account of the lavish promises of Shah Shuja, and partly for fear of the Baluchis who grew in number every day, the armies marched on. Many people were killed by the tribesmen. They murdered everyone whenever they had the opportunity and rolled large boulders down the mountain sides.[39]

Mirza 'Ata wrote that the entourage of Shah Shuja also felt lucky to make it through alive, as they dodged the bullets raining down on the column from Baluch snipers sheltering in the faults and crevices of the rocks above. 'The army entered the defiles of the Bolan Pass,' he wrote.

> The pass was rugged and stony, ringed with mountain peaks scraping the sky: the army gazed in dismay, and the Baluch mountain tribesmen did not delay to snipe and plunder. Thousands of pack-animals, camels, horses, elephants and their loads were lost.
>
> Crossing the pass was extremely difficult: already two months earlier the English had sent two cannons and thousands of donkey-loads of gun-powder to the pass in order to clear the route, and had had to drag them up one by one with ropes; other supplies were transported with similar difficulty, at the cost of losing a great number of camels, horses, bullocks, as well as soldiers who died from lack of water and food – not to mention the military equipment that was plundered. In that waterless hellish defile they spent three days and nights, and supplies were so scarce that half a seer of flour could not be had even for a gold rupee.[40]

For his part, Shuja wrote to Wade from the pass that he intended to punish the tribesmen of the area 'for their criminal attitude, at a proper time'. He